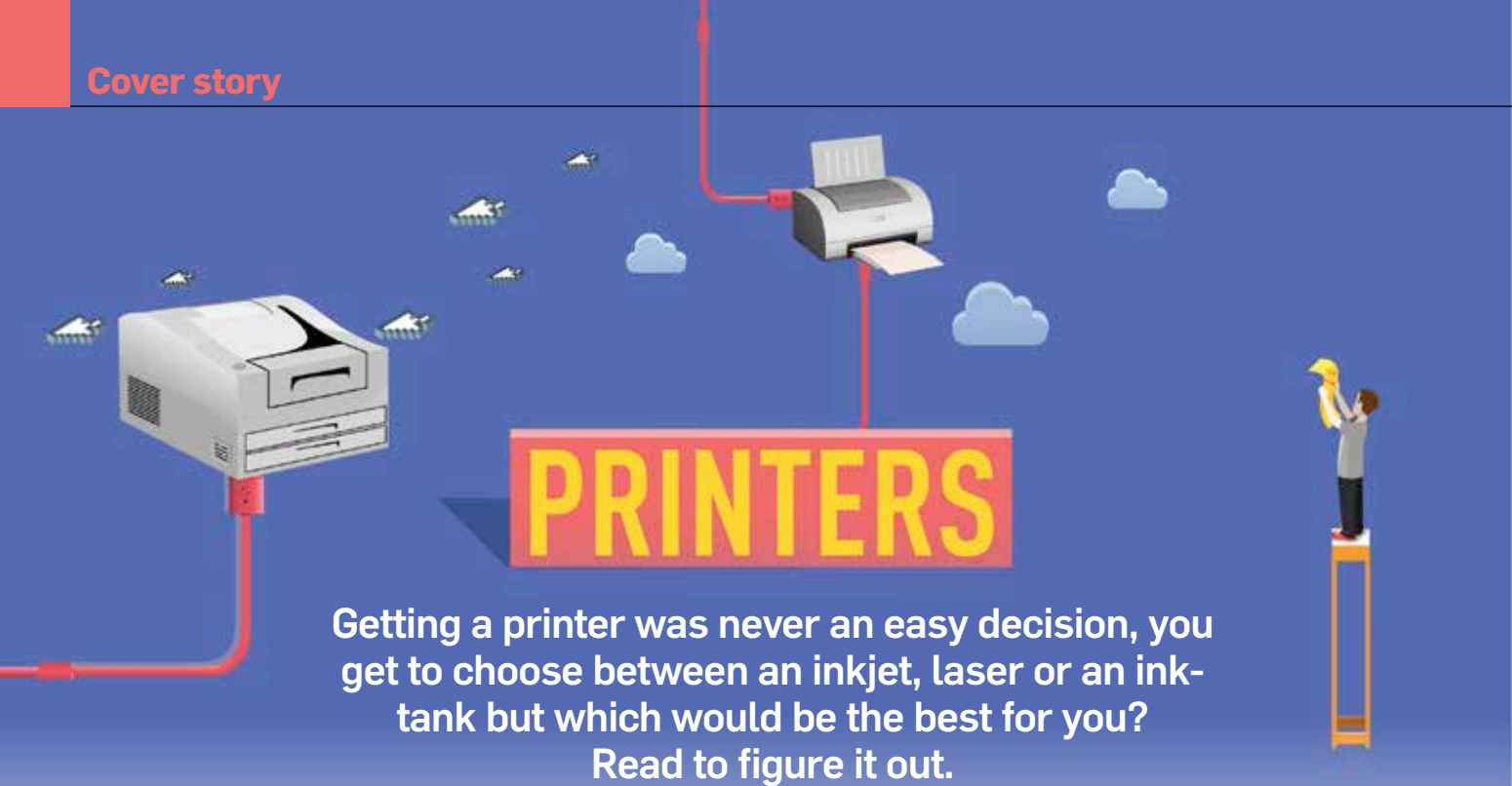




Getting a printer was never an easy decision, you get to choose between an inkjet, laser or an ink-tank but which would be the best for you? Read to figure it out.

By **Anirudh Regidi**

As much as we'd like to believe that we're shifting to a paperless world, printers are still necessary and very relevant today. That said, this is one aspect of tech that you probably don't want to think too much about. Bearing that in mind, our test processes are designed to identify a printer that is eminently reliable, a great performer and non-intrusive. Here, we'll let you in on some of the secrets to behind the art of testing printers.

Types of printers

As far as we're concerned, there are only three prominent types of printers:

- 1. Inkjet printers:** These are the most common type of colour printers available today and can range from dirt cheap to exorbitantly expensive. The cheap printers are best for the occasional colour print-out at home, but usually run out of ink extremely fast and two sets of cartridges can cost as much or more than the printer itself. The more expensive photo printer variants of these will also cost an arm and a leg to run, but are the only printers capable of offering you high quality photo prints.
- 2. Laser printers:** These are as integral to a SOHO and other type of office as an office chair. A little more expensive

than a cheap inkjet for sure, but laser printers almost never jam and will reliably just keep churning out print-out after print-out without complaint and at an operating cost that's negligible. You get colour versions of laser printers as well, but the quality is only restricted to something you'd want from an office document or Powerpoint Presentation and definitely not something you'd want for photo prints.

- 3. Ink-tank printers:** Ink-tank technology is a relatively new entrant to the printer space and is taking the printing world by storm, if only for the ridiculously cheap colour prints that you can get from such printers. Think of these printers as quite literally using a pot of ink to print your documents.



Is print volume the only factor?

The prints thus acquired are usually prone to smudging and won't last too long, but they're dirt cheap, sometimes going to as little as ₹0.5 per page for a colour print.

Therefore, the choice of printer for you is as follows:

- The occasional print-out: Inkjet
- SOHO/high volume prints: Laser
- Medium-high volume colour prints: Ink-tank

DO

Now that you've settled on a printer, here's what you can DO to test these printers:

1. Inkjet printers

Since image quality is the priority here, you'll need to actually print an image and check the quality. You can use the image available at <http://dgit.in/1e8jxJX> to test, but it'll be best if you find an image that you're very familiar with and take a print of that.

You need to look for the following:

Colour accuracy: Compare the output print with the image on a calibrated display. You usually won't have a calibrated display handy but usually, your mobile phone's screen will be the best one on hand. If you have an iPhone or iPad, you're in luck as these devices have among the best displays available in the market.